ation. The Court's decisions involving associational freedoms establish that the right of association is a "basic constitutional freedom," *Kusper* v. *Pontikes,* 414 U. S., at 57, that is "closely allied to freedom of speech and a right which, like free speech, lies at the foundation of a free society." *Shelton* v. *Tucker,* 364 U. S. 479, 486 (1960). See, *e. g., Bates* v. *Little Rock,* 361 U. S. 516, 522–523 (1960); *NAACP* v. *Alabama, supra,* at 460–461; *NAACP* v. *Button, supra,* at 452 (Harlan, J., dissenting). In view of the fundamental nature of the right to associate, governmental "action which may have the effect of curtailing the freedom to associate is subject to the closest scrutiny." *NAACP* v. *Alabama, supra,* at 460–461. Yet, it is clear that "[n]either the right to associate nor the right to participate in political activities is absolute." *CSC* v. *Letter Carriers,* 413 U. S. 548, 567 (1973). Even a " 'significant interference' with protected rights of political association" may be sustained if the State demonstrates a sufficiently important interest and employs means closely drawn to avoid unnecessary abridgment of associational freedoms. *Cousins* v. *Wigoda, supra,* at 488; *NAACP* v. *Button, supra,* at 438; *Shelton* v. *Tucker, supra,* at 488.

Appellees argue that the Act's restrictions on large campaign contributions are justified by three governmental interests. According to the parties and *amici,* the primary interest served by the limitations and, indeed, by the Act as a whole, is the prevention of corruption and the appearance of corruption spawned by the real or imagined coercive influence of large financial contributions on candidates' positions and on their actions if elected to office. Two "ancillary" interests underlying the Act are also allegedly furthered by the $1,000 limits on contributions. First, the limits serve to mute the voices of affluent persons and groups in the election